

FIELD OF VISION | SHARDA UGRA

Just Overdoing It

Just after India won the World T20, INDIA TODAY asked John Buchanan, regarded as one of the forward thinkers of the game, for his projection of what he thought Twenty20 would be like in the year 2020. Buchanan's 2020 blueprint contained some truly futuristic ideas, but nothing about four captains. The main task for strategists, (captains, coaches) he believed, would be reducing boundary hits, with the focus on precision in bowling, anticipation in fielding and a greater use of the 'set-play'. There were other things: a signalling system between bowler and wicket-keeper and being able to rotate 15 players in a match rather than sticking to 11 from a teamsheet.

It sounded all very cutting-edge then; post-IPL, it seems very routine. Hell, they could introduce breaks for ad spots after 10 overs and even have two IPL seasons per year, so what's the big deal about 15-per-side or four captains? The IPL works on few principles but there's one it clearly recognises: Just Overdo It.

Yet, the idea of several 'captains' on a team is neither new nor radical. Under Sourav Ganguly, various players were given charge of different departments in the game and they led the analysis in team meetings. Dhoni's India does it too. Yet all the time, everyone knows who the captain is. Buchanan and the Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) have backtracked on the multiple captains now and say they will have 'strategists' instead, a group of their most seasoned players to advise the main man. Like all good teams have already.

But it's very obvious KKR wanted to change captains. The younger, more durable Brendon McCullum was meant to be the new man but Buchanan and assistant Matthew Mott decided that keeping, batting and captaincy would be too much for the Kiwi. Buchanan's Plan-B ran aground, but if he can ever push it through, it will mark the transfer of power from captain to coach in cricket.

The power to pick 11 from 15 in the dugout is nothing but soccer-style substitution

by the soccer-style cricket coach, who can call in the slow-moving batsman or wasteful bowler. The IPL's team owners will be happy to let the coach call the shots as long as he delivers titles.

But for many in IPL cricket ops, carrying an army platoon in support staff—Rajasthan Royals may take 11, including two securitymen, to South Africa—now offers another radical idea. They say that in a T20 match everyone knows what is to be done and what the opposition is trying to do. There are few strategic surprises, and tactics follow a pattern which, at the moment, render elaborate game plans somewhat redundant.

Could it just be possible that on any given T20 game day, other than putting out the cones and making sure everyone has good training workouts, there is actually little need for um... a coach?

SAURABH SINGH



SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Germany-born **Sister Mary Prema** as the superior general of the Missionaries of Charity founded by Nobel



Peace Prize winner Mother Teresa.

EXTENDED: Till June, the tenure of the **Liberhan Commission** set up in December 1992 to probe the Babri Masjid demolition. This is its 48th extension, making it the longest-serving commission of inquiry.

DONATED: The organs of 16-month-old **Abhilasha Rahurikar** by her parents, making her India's youngest-ever cadaver organ donor. Abhilasha died of hydrocephalus, a rare neurological condition in which cerebrospinal fluid accumulates in the brain.

DIED: **Kanwaljit Singh**, 67, Punjab minister for cooperation and general secretary of the ruling Shiromani Akali Dal, in a road accident near Chandigarh.

